AMERICAN VOICES

1.2 Frederick Douglass 1818–1895

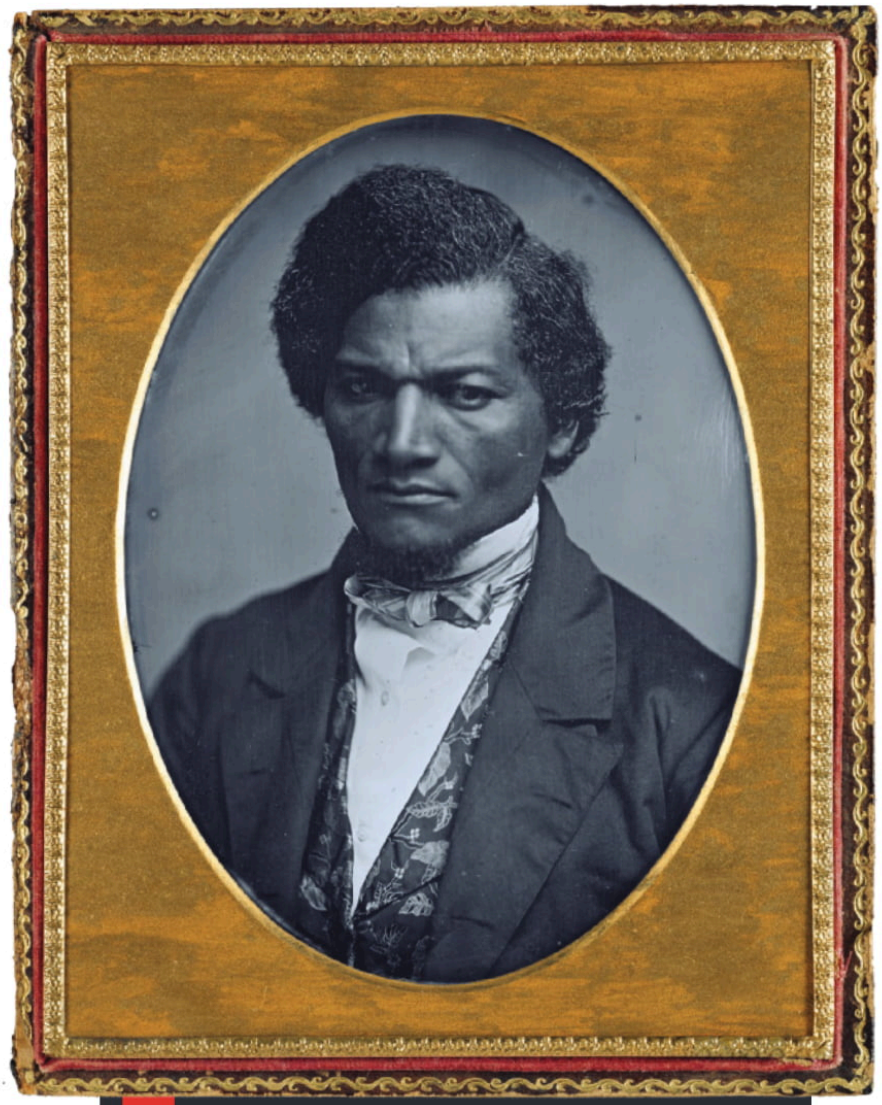
"The white man's happiness cannot be purchased by the black man's misery."—Frederick Douglass

Frederick Douglass was deeply familiar with the miseries suffered by black men and women living in slavery. Born to an enslaved mother in 1818, he spent the early years of his childhood living on a plantation in Maryland. There, he endured cold and hunger, and he witnessed other slaves being whipped.

BALTIMORE AND BEYOND

When he was around eight years old, Douglass was sent to live in Baltimore with a shipbuilder named Hugh Auld. Auld's wife Sophia taught the young boy the alphabet. Auld quickly put a stop to the lessons because it was illegal to teach a slave to read. However, the child's passion for learning had been ignited, and he taught himself to read and write.

In 1832, Douglass was sent to work on a plantation, where he was regularly beaten and given little to eat. In his own words, he was "broken in body, soul, and spirit" as "the dark night of slavery closed in upon me." Eventually, he returned to Baltimore to work in the shipyards, where he made his escape in 1838 by fleeing to New York City. After his escape, he changed his name to reduce the risk of being found by slave catchers. Before, he had been called Frederick Augustus Washington Bailey. From this point on, he would call himself Frederick Douglass.



Art Institute of Chicago

This photograph by Samuel J. Miller shows Frederick Douglass in formal dress, staring forcefully at the viewer. Douglass, the most photographed American of the 19th century, insisted on posing this way. He wanted to reteach people how to see African Americans by replacing the stereotype of the oppressed slave with the portrait of a dignified, proud fellow citizen.

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FIGHTER FOR FREEDOM

Douglass settled in New Bedford, Massachusetts, where he worked as a laborer and furthered his education by reading widely. In 1841, he made his first speech describing his life in slavery and calling for an end to the brutal practice. It was the beginning of a lifelong career in public speaking.

Douglass's speeches were so eloquent that some people suspected him of simply pretending to be a former slave. They reasoned that a man born in slavery could never have learned to speak with such brilliance. In many ways, Douglass remade how his fellow citizens viewed African Americans.

To tell his full story, Douglass wrote *Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass, an American Slave* in 1845. Publishing the autobiography was a special act of courage because it revealed details about his life that might enable slave catchers to find him. He traveled to Great Britain, where he promoted his book and gave lectures. There, he could speak out without fear of being captured. Over the course of his two-year tour, he gained many new friends and supporters, who helped him purchase his freedom.

Back in the United States, Douglass founded an abolitionist newspaper, wrote two more influential books, and continued to speak out. In 1852, he delivered one of his most famous speeches, "The Meaning of July Fourth for the Negro." In it, he asked why enslaved people should celebrate the country's freedom when they did not benefit from it themselves. "We need the storm, the whirlwind, the earthquake," he thundered. "[The] conscience of the nation must be roused."

When the Civil War broke out, Douglass helped recruit African-American soldiers, and he met with President Abraham Lincoln several times. After the war he held various government posts, including U.S. Marshall for the District of Columbia. He continued promoting civil rights for all Americans until his death in 1895.



CRITICAL VIEWING This painting, *Three Great Abolitionists: A. Lincoln, F. Douglass, J. Brown,* was created by William H. Johnson around 1945. Frederick Douglass stands in the middle, clasping hands with Abraham Lincoln on his left and John Brown on his right. Johnson depicted the three using a "primitive" style of painting, characterized by the work's bright colors and two-dimensional figures. Just behind John Brown, African Americans raise their hands in celebration of the abolitionists. What aspects of Civil War–era African-American life are depicted in the background of the painting?

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why was Douglass in danger of being enslaved again, even after he became well known?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** How did a few lessons from Sophia Auld change the course of Douglass's life?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** Why do you think Douglass took the Fourth of July as a theme for a speech on slavery?

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